Figure 2.11 The client (browser) initiates the HTTP request, which is sent to the server. The server is responsible for routing the request to the configured application and returning an HTTP response.

An HTTP request comprises a number of pieces of data. The first line (start line) of the request message includes the following:

- The HTTP method
- The identifier of the resource
- The protocol version (e.g., HTTP/1.1)

The method is represented by a verb (e.g., `GET`, `POST`, `PUT`, `DELETE`, `TRACE`, or `CONNECT`) or a noun (e.g., `HEAD` or `OPTIONS`). The most commonly used methods for requests to websites are `GET` and `POST`, where `GET` is primarily used to request data from the server and `POST` is primarily used to transmit data to the server, although the `POST` method may also result in data being sent back to the client. These are the only two methods that will be covered in this book.

The identifier is represented by a uniform resource identifier (URI). This particular piece of data is also commonly referred to as a uniform resource locator (URL), as if they represent the same thing. Technically, they differ. For the purposes of this book, it is enough to know that all URLs are URIs, but not all URIs are URLs. Section 1.1.3 of RFC3986 explains the differences in detail: https://www.ietf.org/rfc/rfc3986.txt. The type of URI I will use in examples will be a URL in all cases.

The request also includes a collection of headers—name-value pairs that can be used to provide additional information to the server that might affect its response. For example, the `If-Modified-Since` header specifies a `datetime` value. If the requested resource has not been modified since